

RELIGIOUS STUDIES

The Religious Studies major (27 credits) and minor (15 credits) offer Iowa State University students the opportunity to expand their knowledge about diverse religions in the United States and the world. The major and minor allow students to design their own unique program of study by taking courses that spark their interest. Religious Studies teaches students to explore religion objectively, critically, and empathetically. It equips students to apply academic theories and methods to understand how religions shape and are shaped by history, politics, culture, society, and human psychology. As their religious literacy increases, students will develop their own ideas about the nature of religion, life's big questions, and the wide range of human ideas, practices, and motivations.

The major in Religious Studies provides both breadth and depth. The program's 2000-level courses introduce students to the academic study of religion, providing a foundation that students build on throughout their undergraduate career. In 3000-level courses, students closely investigate particular traditions, topics, or themes. Throughout their undergraduate career, students have opportunities to connect their program of study to their own professional and personal goals.

The Religious Studies program provides students skills relevant to building a career based on their interests and passions. Contrary to popular myths, employers in today's modern workplace value college graduates with liberal arts degrees. In Religious Studies, these include the "hard skills" of writing, reading, and conducting organized research. Students also gain so-called "soft skills." These include communication strategies, learning to adapt to new environments, and the capacity to work with and understand people from diverse backgrounds. The flexibility of these skills opens up a wide range of career paths. Religious Studies graduates pursue careers in non-profits, community organizations, and people-focused industries. They apply to graduate and professional schools in areas such as law, education, and ministry. A Religious Studies degree doesn't just help students *get* a job. It helps them advance and grow, both professionally and personally, well into their lives.

Student Learning Outcomes

Upon graduation, students should be able to:

1. Describe religious diversity in the United States and around the world, including diversity within traditions.
2. Identify key beliefs, doctrines, practices, and expressions of multiple religions.
3. Explain how religion has shaped and been shaped by human history, culture, and society, drawing on historical, cultural, and textual analyses.

4. Distinguish between confessional and academic understandings of religion.
5. Assess data produced by and about religious communities in an objective, critical, and empathetic manner.
6. Create and convey original insights using effective reading, research, writing, and conversation skills.

Religious Studies - Undergraduate Study

Students pursuing a major in religious studies must complete a minimum of 27 credits, including the requirements below. Students may also choose to do a senior thesis under the supervision of a religious studies faculty advisor. This option may earn 3-6 credits toward the completion of the major.

Two of the following introductory survey courses of which one must be either 2050 or 2100 6

RELIG 2050	World Religions
or RELIG 2100 Religion in America	
RELIG 2150	Religion and Popular Culture
RELIG 2420	History of Christianity: Early to Medieval
RELIG 2430	History of Christianity: Modern
RELIG 2770	Religion and Society

Five of the following 3000+ level courses 15

RELIG 3220	The New Testament
RELIG 3250	Religion, Law, and Justice
RELIG 3280	Native American Religions
RELIG 3320	Catholicism
RELIG 3340	Africana Religions
RELIG 3360	Religion, Sex and Gender
RELIG 3390	Goddess Religions
RELIG 3400	Magic, Witchcraft, and Religion
RELIG 3480	Psychology of Religion
RELIG 3490	Cognitive Science of Religion
RELIG 3500	Philosophy of Religion
RELIG 3520	Religions of India
RELIG 3580	Islam
RELIG 3590	The Quran
RELIG 3670	Christianity in the Roman Empire
RELIG 3680	Religions of Ancient Greece and Rome
RELIG 3700	Religion and Politics
RELIG 3800	Catholic Social Thought
RELIG 3890	Exhibiting Religion

Any other RELIG 3000- or 4000-level course

Minimum of 6 credits of elective Religious Studies courses	6
Total Credits	27

Communication Proficiency

ENGL 1500	Critical Thinking and Communication	3
ENGL 2500	Written, Oral, Visual, and Electronic Composition	3

To meet the upper-level ISU Communication requirement, Religious Studies majors choose from one of the following:

ENGL 3020	Business Communication	
	or ENGL 309 Proposal and Report Writing	
	or ENGL 314 Technical Communication	
	or RELIG 322 The New Testament	
	or RELIG 325 Religion, Law, and Justice	
	or RELIG 328 Native American Religions	
	or RELIG 332 Catholicism	
	or RELIG 352 Religions of India	
	or RELIG 355 The Quran	
	or RELIG 385 Exhibiting Religion	
Total Credits		6-9

Students in all ISU majors must complete a three-credit course in U.S. Cultures and Communities and a three-credit course in International Perspectives. Check (<http://www.registrar.iastate.edu/courses/div-ip-guide.html>) for a list of approved courses. Discuss with your advisor how the two courses that you select can be applied to your graduation plan.

According to the university-wide Communication Proficiency Grade Requirement (<https://catalog.iastate.edu/academics/#communicationproficiencypolicytext>), students must demonstrate their communication proficiency by earning a grade of C or better in ENGL 2500.

LAS majors require a minimum of 120 credits, **including a minimum of 45 credits at the 3000/4000 level**. Students must also complete the LAS College requirements (<https://catalog.iastate.edu/collegeofliberalartsandsciences/>), including the world language requirement and career proficiency requirement.

Religious Studies, B.A.

Freshman

Fall	Credits Spring	Credits
ENGL 1500	3 Religion Choice 2000+ or 3000+	3
LIB 1600	1 World Language/Elective	4
RELIG 2050 or 2100	3 Humanities Choice	3
World Language/Elective	4 Social Science Choice	3

Humanities Choice	3 Elective	3
Math Choice	3	
	17	16

Sophomore

Fall	Credits Spring	Credits
Religion Choice 2000+ or 3000+	3 Religion Choice 3000+	3
ENGL 2500	3 Natural Science Choice ¹	4
Humanities Choice	3 Social Science Choice	3
Natural Science Choice ¹	4 Humanities Choice	3
Social Science Choice	3 Elective	2-3
	LAS 2030	1
	16	16-17

Junior

Fall	Credits Spring	Credits
Religion Choice 3000+	3 Religion Choice 3000+	3
Elective	3 Elective	3
Elective	4 Elective	3
Elective	3 Elective	3
Elective	3 Elective	3
	16	15

Senior

Fall	Credits Spring	Credits
Religion Choice 3000+	3 Religion Elective	3
Religion Elective	3 Elective	3
Elective	3 Elective	3
Elective	4 Elective	3
	13	12

¹ Laboratory science recommended.

The program offers a minor that may be earned by completing a total of 15 credits in religious studies including either RELIG 2050 World Religions or RELIG 2100 Religion in America. Nine credits of the minor must be numbered 2000 level or above, of which at least 6 credits are in courses numbered 3000 level or above (no more than 3 hours of seminar and no more than 3 hours of independent study). The minor must include at least 3 credits that are not used to meet any other department, college or university requirement, and 3 credits must be earned at Iowa State University.

The Religious Studies Undergraduate Minor is an LAS Minor. In addition to University policies governing minors (<https://catalog.iastate.edu/>

academics/#degreeplanningtext), LAS minors require at least 6 credits in courses numbered 3000 and above, with a grade of C or higher.

Religious Studies - Graduate Study

Religious studies may be one of the three areas used for the interdisciplinary graduate studies master's degree.